



**LIVE LIKE A ZAMORIN**
Top, A bountiful thali at the restaurant of Neeleshwar Hermitage; right, the houseboat Lotus on a cruise; below, an infinity pool at the resort overlooking the beach



## DOWN BY THE SEA

From the highlands to the Arabian Sea, I roll into Neeleshwar Hermitage where I am welcomed into 12 acres of a dream-like sprawl on which 18 standalone cottages wait invitingly for weary heads. I walk into my sea-facing room, built in the traditional style but with plush comforts, a plunge pool and porch sit-outs. Though fresh off a five-hour drive, I find it hard to stop myself from leaving my bags and trotting across the measly 200 metres of pathways that cut through grass, on to the unspoiled Ozhinhavalappu beach, and right into the sea.

Healing and rejuvenation form the pillars of the Hermitage's credo: the Priya Spa offers holistic treatments based on consultations with the inhouse Ayurveda practitioner, while the dawn echoes with expert-led pranayam and asanas at the seaside yoga centre. Meals are served in open restaurants flooded with ocean breeze. Sustainability flows through every detail—from composting to no-plastic policies and thoughtfully sourced cuisine.

The highlight, however, is a sojourn aboard The Lotus—the retreat's 100-foot houseboat—for one- to two-night journeys through rabble-free backwaters. And then there is the transformative experience of witnessing Theyyam—a ritual dance form native to North Kerala. Rooted in the worship of ancestral and local deities, Theyyam is both an act of devotion and resistance. For centuries, it has been performed by members of lower castes who, during these rituals, embody the spirit of divine figures. I find the paradox striking: a Brahmin priest bowing before a Dalit man possessed by the spirit of the divine Muthappan. In that fire-lit moment, caste, class and creed collapse into shared awe.

North Kerala rewards the slow traveller—with stories that unfold gently, landscapes that linger, and moments that stay long after you've left. ■